DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Is Prophecy a Gift or Earned?

Derech Hashem 3:5:5-6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 5, paragraphs 5-6 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 10 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: the other prophets

The recording begins as the Rabbi reminds the group that prophecy has nothing essentially to do with preaching; preaching is incidental, and prophecy is the intimate vision of God. He then recalled the previous class: all other prophets lost their physical faculties during prophecy; they saw through a metaphorical lens or mirror, more or less polished according to their level; and their prophecy came in riddles that had to be interpreted.

Paragraph 5: Moshe awake, with a clear lens

Moshe's prophecy was higher in several ways. He had no need to lose his faculties: he received prophecy in his regular, waking state. That is what God means by "mouth to mouth I speak to him", as two people speak while awake.

He also saw through one lens only, and a polished one: as clear a perception of the Shekhinah as a human being can have. And the message came clearly, "in a vision and not in riddles", because his perception was so clear.

But do not think that Moshe saw God. Even for Moshe it was like an image reflected in a mirror, because it is impossible for a human being to fully grasp his Creator: "no man can see Me and live". A participant asked whether that applies even after death. The Rabbi: yes, one never sees the Shekhinah itself. The pasuk says "the *temunah*, the form, of God he beholds": a picture, a reflection, which Moshe gazed at very clearly, but still a picture. The other prophets did not even see the picture properly.

A participant asked whether the message is always equally clear and only the recipient's capacity differs. The Rabbi answered that for Moshe it came "on a plate", and that clarity was itself a sign of his closeness to God, which also brought him a deeper understanding with every prophecy.

Paragraph 6: prophecy at will

Another difference: other prophets could not prophesy whenever they wished, but only when God chose to rest His presence on them. Moshe could turn to God at any time.

Where do we see this in the Torah? The group offered examples, and the Rabbi dwelt on one. When the men who were impure and could not bring the Pesah offering asked "why should we lose out?", Moshe said, "Stand and I will hear what God commands concerning you." He was fully confident he would receive an answer immediately. No other prophet could do that. Even after all the training, it remained up to God whether to rest His prophecy on them.

The Rambam versus the Kuzari and the Ramban

The Rabbi described how the prophets prepared, as the Rambam writes: meditating and focusing, in a state of joy, never in sadness or laziness, with harps, drums and cymbals.

He then set out a fundamental disagreement he had discussed when teaching the Thirteen Principles. For the Kuzari and the Ramban, prophecy is a kind of miracle: God sees a simple, God-fearing person who means well and elevates him into a prophet. The Rambam, and the Ramhal with him, reject this. Prophecy is an intellectual discipline that you work towards. The only miracle in prophecy, for the Rambam, is the reverse: a person may complete every stage of preparation and God may still decide not to make him a prophet.

So far, three differences: whether the prophet loses his senses; whether he sees through a clean, polished lens; and whether he can choose when to connect.

Moshe in the fields

A participant asked whether Moshe's prophecy began at the burning bush. The Rabbi said his real prophecy began there, but Moshe must have been preparing. The Torah tells us almost nothing of his life between fleeing Egypt as a young man and the burning bush at eighty: some sixty-five years as a shepherd. He must have lived a reclusive, meditative life in the fields.

"I always say": read the pesukim in Parashat Shemot. Moshe saw that the bush was burning and was not consumed, and turned aside to look. And when God saw that he turned aside to look, He called to him. The decisive factor, the Rabbi suggested, was Moshe's curiosity about the natural world: "I know the rules of physics. I know that this should be burning, it's not, therefore I want to pay attention to this." God saw that and chose him. Even so, he probably did not become the great prophet he was from one day to the next. The discussion continues in the next recording.

Summary

- Moshe prophesied awake, through one clear lens, with messages free of riddles.
- Even Moshe saw only a reflection, the *temunah*, never God Himself.
- Moshe could seek prophecy whenever he wished, as with the question of Pesah Sheni.
- For the Rambam and the Ramhal prophecy is earned through discipline; the miracle is only when God withholds it.
- Moshe's curiosity at the burning bush shows the meditative mind that prepared him.

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